

McKay Orchestra Handbook 21-22



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Introduction

Welcome to the McKay High School Orchestra Program! Whether you are new to McKay or you've been here a while, I'm excited to see you and make music this year. If you don't know me, I'm Mr. Figueroa, and this will be my second year teaching at McKay. The purpose of this handbook is to serve as a reference throughout the year to make sure we're all on the same page when it comes to orchestra events, responsibilities, and behavior. If you have any questions, the best way to contact me is by email. figueroa_alexander@salkeiz.k12.or.us

Instruments

If you are not currently renting an instrument, we're lucky to have great music shops in town that work hard to make sure you have everything you'll need. I recommend both stores equally. Here is a list of their information:

Uptown Music - 3827 River Rd N, Keizer, OR 97303 <https://www.uptownmusicnw.com/>
503-393-4437

Willamette Valley Music - 484 State St, Salem, OR 97301 <https://www.wvmc.net/>
503-385-8790

If renting is not a possibility for you, let me know, and we'll come up with a plan to get an instrument in your hands ASAP.

Purchasing your own instrument

When the time has come to upgrade or purchase your own instrument, please follow the procedures below:

1. Contact several instrument dealers in order to compare prices for new and used instruments. Newspapers also advertise the sale of musical instruments. Your Director may also have information on available instruments.
2. Decide on the amount of money that you can afford to spend.
3. Set up appointments at the stores you choose. Take music and your child. Have them play each instrument. After you have decided on 2 or 3 instruments, contact your school Director.

****Do not purchase an instrument without consulting your child's director.****

I strongly recommend that you don't purchase instruments from unreliable online vendors like Amazon and Ebay. Buying an instrument is like buying a car. It's important to test out the instrument to make sure it is a good fit for you!

Miscellaneous Equipment

Students should own the following items:

1. A cake of rosin
2. A cleaning cloth
3. Rock stop for cellist and bassists
4. Reliable shoulder rest for violin and viola
5. Music stand

If acquiring these items is a problem, talk with me, and we will figure out a solution to get you these items.

Instrument Repair

Students should only use a music dealer instrument polish. DO NOT use household polish on your stringed instrument. It could damage the varnish on the instrument. DO NOT attempt to do your own repairs.

I advise that you bring the broken instrument into the school first to see if I can fix it with the materials at school. If I can't fix it, then go to a music store, and they will be able to help!

High School Uniform Requirements

Students are provided with school orchestra uniforms. These uniforms are all black and come in black dress shirts/black pants or a black dress. Students are expected to have their own long black socks and black shoes.

Concert Attendance

Attendance at all performances is MANDATORY. The orchestra is a performing GROUP. The entire group will suffer if one person is missing. I realize that conflicts can occur; this is why I distribute our concert dates during the first full week of school so families can plan vacations and extra-curricular activities around their child's orchestra concerts.

Excused Absence: Students must provide a written note from their parent/guardian indicating they will be missing a performance. This note must include the date of the performance, the reason for absence and the parent/guardian's daytime phone number. These notes are due to Mr. Figueroa by October 1, 2021. At this time, your child will receive their excused absence assignment for that concert. This assignment must be submitted to your child's orchestra director the day before the concert or before they leave for their planned destination.

Emergency Excused Absence: The following are considered excused absences: Death in the family and illness. A note must be presented to the teacher the first day back to school after the emergency.

Unexcused Absence: A student that is absent from a concert will receive an unexcused absence if the orchestra director is not presented a note by the October 1, 2021 deadline. They will also receive an unexcused absence if a note is not presented after an emergency absence. If a student misses a performance for a family birthday party, work conflict, lack of transportation to the performance, or any other conflict that could have been avoided with proper planning the student will be given an unexcused absence. Always feel free to contact me when conflicts arise! I understand life happens, so if we communicate about a problem, we'll be able to find a solution that works for everyone.

Consequence for an Unexcused Absence: A high school student's grade will be lowered two letter grades and an additional assignment will be given. This assignment will be due one week after the concert; if this is not turned in then the grade will be lowered one more letter grade.

Concert Behavior

1. Students are to arrive for the concert at their call-time. There is always a lot to do before the concert, so it is very important to be early.
2. Students are required to attend the full concert to support their fellow orchestra members unless they are excused by the director. You will only be excused with a parent/guardian note. If you leave without excuse from the director, that will lower your concert grade by 50%, which equals a one letter drop in your orchestra grade
3. Students will be respectful of the other groups playing by staying silent until the performance is over
4. All other conduct policies reflect the McKay Student Code of Conduct

2021-2022 Concert Dates

*All dates listed are mandatory if your orchestra group is participating

Thursday	Oct 28, 2021	Orchestra Concert
Thur-Sun	Nov 11-14, 2021	OCYOF (Chamber, overnight trip)
Monday	Dec 13, 2021	Intermediate Rehearsal
Tuesday	Dec 14, 2021	Intermediate Winter Concert
Wednesday	Dec 15, 2021	Adv Rehearsal
Thursday	Dec 16, 2021	Adv Winter Concert
Saturday	Feb 19, 2022	All-City Concert
Friday	Feb 25, 2022	Four Seasons Concert
Tues-Wed	Mar 8-9, 2022	Intermediate Orchestra Festival
Tuesday	Mar 15, 2022	Freshmen Concert
Thursday	Mar 31, 2022	Adv Orchestra Preview
Saturday	Apr 9, 2022	Districts
Wed-Thur	Apr 20-21, 2022	Adv Orchestra Festival
Wednesday	May 11, 2022	State Contest
Wednesday	June 1, 2022	Senior Concert

Grading

The grading scale for McKay HS is the same as the Orchestra grading scale:

A= 90-100

B= 80-89

C= 70-79

D= 60-69

F= 59 or lower

A student's grade will be determined by the following categories:

- Concert Attendance (student attends all concerts on time)
- Class Preparedness (arrived with instrument, music, rosin, etc.)
- Behavior (participation in class, writing in music, etc.)
- Practice Journals
- Miscellaneous assignments

Practice Journals

Some of you may have had practice charts in the past where you'd write down how many minutes you practiced that week and had a parent/guardian sign it. *Practice journals are a bit different.*

Practice journals are where you tell me what you practiced, how long you practiced, and the ways you practiced it. The reason for this assignment is to guide your practice so you can be more efficient in what you want to get done. It's better to have focused practice for 15 minutes than distracted practice for an hour.

Varsity Letters

New this year, you'll be able to earn a varsity letter for being an involved member in orchestra! To earn a letter, you must meet all 3 of the following requirements*:

- Compete in an OSAA group for two years; either chamber, symphony, or solo & ensemble
- Participate in four Orchestra fundraising events throughout your time at McKay (Music Day, perform at fundraising concerts, any other orchestra fundraiser)
- Audition for an extracurricular ensemble once (SYS, All-City, All-State)

*Non-freshmen will be phased into these requirements. If you're a senior, you only need one of each requirement. Juniors only need 2, etc.